
File Case #5

Case ID: 301F **Case Title:** The "Digital Ransom" Case **Date:** May 3, 2021 **Status:** Closed (Partial Resolution)

Crime Summary: The **Metropolitan Central Hospital** suffered a massive cyberattack. A **ransomware** known as "**Cerberus**" encrypted all patient records, appointment systems, and internal databases, paralyzing the hospital. The attackers demanded a **50 Bitcoin ransom**.

Modus Operandi (M.O.): The entry point to the hospital network was a **vulnerable IoT (Internet of Things) device**: a **smart thermostat** in a break room that had not been updated. From there, the hackers **escalated privileges** to reach the main server. The "**Cerberus**" ransomware was a new variant, designed to propagate quickly in medical networks.

Persons of Interest:

- **Main Suspect:** A hacker collective known as "**Digital Phantoms**," famous for attacks on critical infrastructure.
- **Victim:** Metropolitan Central Hospital.

Key Evidence:

- Network traffic analysis that identified the initial **breach through the thermostat's IP**.
- The **Bitcoin wallet address** to which the payment was demanded.
- Fragments of the "**Cerberus**" ransomware code that contained a digital signature similar to that used by "Digital Phantoms" in previous attacks.

Forensic Analysis: Analysis of the cryptocurrency wallet revealed that the funds were moved through multiple "**mixers**" to obfuscate their origin. However, a small initial **test transaction** was traced to an exchange that required **KYC (Know Your Customer)**, revealing the identity of a **low-level member** of the group in Eastern Europe.

Resolution: The hospital chose not to pay the ransom and, with the help of experts, was able to **restore most of its systems** from backups. The identified member of "Digital Phantoms" was arrested, but the group's leaders were never caught. It is considered a **partial resolution**.